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Not without Cost

You are not your own; *you were bought with a price.*
—1 Corinthians 6:19–20

God has revealed his innermost secret: God himself
n eternal exchange of love, Father, Son, and Holy
:it, and he has destined us to share in that exchange.
—*Catechism of the Catholic Church* §221

/outh, I was an altar boy. My two favorite responsibilities were ringing the bells and carrying the cross in the procession into the church at the beginning of the Mass. In my parish, there were two options: a metal one, which depicted the Risen Lord—Jesus's arms were outstretched instead of being nailed to the cross—and a traditional wooden crucifix.

One day, the wooden crucifix disappeared from the sacristy. I overheard someone ask about its whereabouts. The priest responded by saying something about the Risen Lord being more comforting to people than an image of Jesus dead on the cross. As we processed into church, I glanced up and saw the most prominent image in the sanctuary: an enormous, larger-than-life crucifix. I recall thinking to myself that if the sight of the smaller processional crucifix caused people difficulties, using the resurrection cross was not going to help them much.

It was impossible to avoid looking at an image of Jesus's death in our church.

Despite its uncomfortable imagery, there is no way to avoid the message of the cross in the New Testament. The biblical writers explicitly link the cross to our "redemption," a term that for ancient Jews came from the world of economics. St. Paul draws this meaning out more explicitly when he says, "You were bought with a price" (1 Corinthians 6:20).

Popular Catholic devotions use this sort of language frequently. For example, each year when we prepare for Christmas, we typically sing "O Come, O Come, Emmanuel," a hymn in which we petition the Lord to "*ransom* captive Israel."

But why is Jesus's death spoken of as "purchasing" salvation? And if God's grace is "free," why the cross? Could God not forgive us without it? Here we come to a central mystery that stands at the heart of salvation history, namely, the mystery of God's love.[1]

REDEMPTION AND THE DEBT OF SIN

The New Testament speaks of Christ not only as the "Savior" but also as the "Redeemer." But what does "redemption" mean? For many, the word is simply a synonym for "salvation." Yet this is not entirely correct. In fact, salvation is a broad term which refers to deliverance or rescue. "Redemption" is narrower in meaning than "salvation." It offers an important metaphor to describe *how* one is saved. Specifically, "redemption" is a term taken from the world of economics.

1 My discussion of the cross relies heavily on the fuller treatment in Pitre, Barber, and Kincaid, *Paul*, chapter 4.

Redemption, Economics, and the Family

Already in the Old Testament, God describes his saving work in terms of "redemption." When the Lord speaks to Moses about delivering Israel from slavery to Pharaoh in Egypt, God describes this as "redeeming" the people: ". . . I will deliver you from their bondage, and I will *redeem* you with an outstretched arm" (Exodus 6:6). God is thus frequently spoken of as Israel's "redeemer."

In the Old Testament, the Hebrew word translated "redeemer" is *gō'ēl*. The term is not merely a theological concept. "Redemption" was part of everyday life. It was a concept specifically related to financial imagery, in particular, debt. Indeed, in the ancient world, debt represented a very serious matter.

In the case of an especially grave debt, a person could sell off one's ancestral land to pay off a creditor (Leviticus 25:25–34). This represented a drastic course of action. In agrarian societies like ancient Israel's, the land was a family's principal source of income. If even selling off your land would not suffice to pay off the debt, you might be forced to sell yourself into slavery (cf. Leviticus 25:39, 47–48). This meant catastrophic personal ruin. In some cases, your spouse and children could also apparently be taken as slaves (cf. 2 Kings 4:1–7).

Nonetheless, the destitute still had hope. According to biblical law, a "redeemer" (*gō'ēl*) could "buy back" another person's land and/or freedom. This task fell to a family member: ". . . *one of his* [the debtor's] *brothers may redeem him*, or *his uncle*, or *his cousin may redeem him*, or *a near kinsman belonging to his family may redeem him*" (cf. Leviticus 25:48–49). The point to underscore here is this: redemption was primarily *a family affair*.

This sheds important light on the biblical story. In Exodus 6, when God promises to deliver his people, he ties this to his

covenant promises to Israel's forefathers, Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, explaining, "I also established my covenant with them" (Exodus 6:4). God says he will "redeem" Israel because "I have remembered my covenant" (Exodus 6:5). By taking on the role of Israel's "redeemer," the Lord is shown to be family to Israel. As we have seen, by virtue of the covenant, God and Israel are united in a familial bond. Redemption is a *family* matter.

Sin, Redemption, and the New Covenant

As we have seen, "redemption" is an economic concept. In connection with this, it is significant to note that in ancient Judaism sin was understood as a "debt." Jesus alludes to this traditional Jewish view when he gives the disciples the words of the "Our Father." Specifically, he tells them to pray, ". . . forgive us our *debts*, as we also have forgiven our *debtors*" (Matthew 6:12).

The language is especially appropriate within a covenant relationship. As we have mentioned, the Jewish scholar Jon D. Levenson notes that a covenant was understood to be a bond of love. In a way, the two parties can be thought of as *owing* love to one another. Sin is a debt within the logic of a relationship defined by *love.* God thus frequently refers to his *love* for Israel as an expression of his faithfulness to the covenant.

In the New Testament, Jesus's death is specifically linked not only to God's love but to covenant imagery. At the Last Supper, Jesus takes the cup and says, "This cup which is poured out for you is *the new covenant* in my blood" (Luke 22:20; cf. 1 Corinthians 11:25). With these words, Jesus alludes to one of the most important prophecies in the Old Testament, which is found in the book of Jeremiah.

In Jeremiah 31, God announces his plan to save his people. This plan is rooted in divine love: "I have loved you with an everlasting love; therefore I have continued my faithfulness

to you" (Jeremiah 31:3). Going on, God tells Israel to rejoice because, "The LORD has *saved* his people, the remnant of Israel" (Jeremiah 31:7). This salvation is then described in terms of "redemption" and "ransom": ". . . the LORD has *ransomed* Jacob, and has *redeemed* him from hands too strong for him" (Jeremiah 31:11). As in the Exodus, God promises to once again take up the role as the people's Redeemer. In doing so, the Lord expresses covenant faithfulness and acts as family to Israel.

Not surprisingly, as in Exodus, God's promise of redemption is linked to the *covenant.* This time God speaks of establishing a "new covenant," through which Israel would *know* the Lord and sins would be forgiven. Although lengthy, it is worth reading the words of the Lord's promise carefully.

> I will make *a new covenant* with the house of Israel and the house of Judah, not like the covenant which I made with their fathers when I took them by the hand to bring them out of the land of Egypt, *my covenant which they broke.* But this is the covenant which I will make with the house of Israel after those days, says the LORD: I will put my law within them, and I will write it upon their hearts . . . And no longer shall each man teach his neighbor and each his brother, saying, "Know the LORD," for they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest, says the LORD; *for I will forgive their iniquity, and I will remember their sin no more.*" (Jeremiah 31:31–33, 34)

This prophecy will have important significance not only for our discussion here but for later chapters in this book as well.

For now, let me highlight one key feature of the prophet's announcement—we are told *why* a new covenant is necessary, namely, the former covenant had been broken because of sin. Here Jeremiah is referring to the events in the book of Exodus. We now turn to consider the story of that first covenant in greater detail.